Himaayah Schools
MADRASAH

FREE GUIDE

أَلَمْ يَجِدْكَ يَتِيمًا فَآوَىٰ

"Did He not find you an orphan and give you refuge?" (aḍ-Ḍuḥā 93:6)

The Makkan Years

From his birth to the Hijrah: childhood, the first revelation, thirteen years of calling, and the road to Madinah.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

The Prophet ﷺ lived about sixty-three years: fifty-three in Makkah and ten in Madinah. In Makkah he grew up an orphan, became known as the most trustworthy man of his people, received the first revelation at forty, and for thirteen years called his people to Allah through mockery, torture, boycott and exile. These years built the faith of the Companions and laid the foundations of Islām: tawḥīd, the prayer, patience and trust in Allah. Our companion book, **The Battles of the Prophet ﷺ**, continues the story in Madinah.

لَقَدْ جَاءَكُمْ رَسُولٌ مِّنْ أَنفُسِكُمْ عَزِيزٌ عَلَيْهِ مَا عَنِتُّمْ حَرِيصٌ عَلَيْكُم بِالْمُؤْمِنِينَ رَءُوفٌ رَّحِيمٌ

“There has certainly come to you a Messenger from among yourselves. Grievous to him is what you suffer; he is concerned over you, and to the believers he is kind and merciful.”

At-Tawbah 9:128.

How this book tells the story

The events are taken from the **Qur’an**, the **authentic ḥadīth** (with the source given), and the **books of sīrah** such as Ibn Isḥāq through Ibn Hishām. Details reported only in the sīrah are marked “it is reported” or “the sīrah books say”, because not all of them have strong chains.

Ages and years are approximate. The scholars differ on some dates, such as the year of al-Isrāʾ wal-Miʿrāj.



Light: the 40 years before Prophethood. Dark: the 13 years of Prophethood in Makkah. Some dates are approximate and some are disputed.

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Part 1 Arabia before Islām

Long before the Prophet ﷺ, Ibrāhīm and his son Ismāʿīl built the **Kaʿbah** in the valley of Makkah as the first house of worship of Allah alone (Āl ʿImrān 3:96; al-Baqarah 2:127). Ismāʿīl's descendants grew into the tribes of the Arabs, and among them was **Quraysh**, who became the guardians of the Kaʿbah. Over centuries, the religion of Ibrāhīm was corrupted. Idols were set up around the Kaʿbah, the Arabs buried some of their daughters alive (at-Takwīr 81:8–9), tribes fought for generations over small matters, the strong oppressed the weak, and wine, gambling and fortune-telling were everywhere. A few people, called the **ḥunafāʾ**, refused the idols and searched for the religion of Ibrāhīm.

Yet the Arabs also had qualities that Islām would build on: generosity to guests, courage, love of freedom, keeping their word, and a language of great richness, which they valued above all in poetry.

The Year of the Elephant

In the year the Prophet ﷺ was born, Abrahah, the Abyssinian ruler of Yemen, marched on Makkah with an army and an elephant to destroy the Kaʿbah, so that the Arabs would go on pilgrimage to the great church he had built in Ṣanʿāʾ. ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib, the Prophet's ﷺ grandfather and chief of Makkah, told Abrahah that he had come for his camels, "and the House has a Lord who will protect it," as the sīrah books report. When the army approached, the elephant knelt and would not move towards Makkah, and Allah sent flocks of birds that pelted the army with stones of baked clay:

> أَلَمْ تَرَ كَيْفَ فَعَلَ رَبُّكَ بِأَصْحَابِ الْفِيلِ
>
> **"Have you not seen how your Lord dealt with the companions of the elephant?"**
>
> Al-Fīl 105:1. Years later, at al-Ḥudaybiyah, the Prophet ﷺ said his camel "was held back by the One who held back the elephant" (al-Bukhārī, 2731).

Part 2 Birth and childhood

Name	Muḥammad ibn ʿAbdillāh ibn ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib ibn Hāshim, of Quraysh, descended from Ismāʿīl son of Ibrāhīm
Born	In Makkah, on a **Monday** (Muslim, 1162) in Rabīʿ al-Awwal, in the Year of the Elephant (around 570–571 CE)
Father	ʿAbdullāh, who died before he was born
Mother	Āminah bint Wahb, of Banū Zuhrah
Wet-nurse	Ḥalīmah as-Saʿdiyyah, of Banū Saʿd, in the desert
Guardians	His grandfather ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib, then his uncle Abū Ṭālib

> إِنَّ اللَّهَ اصْطَفَى كِنَانَةَ مِنْ وَلَدِ إِسْمَاعِيلَ، وَاصْطَفَى قُرَيْشًا مِنْ كِنَانَةَ، وَاصْطَفَى مِنْ قُرَيْشٍ بَنِي هَاشِمٍ، وَاصْطَفَانِي مِنْ بَنِي هَاشِمٍ
>
> **“Allah chose Kinānah from the descendants of Ismāʿīl, chose Quraysh from Kinānah, chose Banū Hāshim from Quraysh, and chose me from Banū Hāshim.”**
>
> Narrated by Muslim (2276).

In the desert with Ḥalīmah

It was the custom of the noble families of Makkah to send their babies to the desert, for its clean air and pure Arabic. The sīrah books tell how Ḥalīmah, poor and with a weak donkey and a dry camel, took the orphan no one else wanted, and how her family’s fortunes changed: her milk flowed, her animals grew fat, and her donkey outpaced the others. While he was a small boy playing with other children, Jibrīl came, laid him down, opened his chest, took out his heart, removed a clot from it and said: “This was Shayṭān’s share of you,” then washed it in a basin of gold with Zamzam water and returned it. The children ran to his foster-mother crying that Muḥammad had been killed (Muslim, 162).

An orphan, three times over

When he was about six, his mother took him to visit his father’s relatives in Madinah, and on the way back she died at **al-Abwā’**. Years later the Prophet ﷺ visited her grave and wept, and those with him wept (Muslim, 976). His grandfather ‘**Abd al-Muṭṭalib** then raised him with great love, and

died when he was about eight. His uncle **Abū Ṭālib**, though poor and with many children, took him in and protected him for the next forty years. Allah reminded him of this care:

> أَلَمْ يَجِدْكَ يَتِيمًا فَآوَىٰ ﴿٦﴾ وَوَجَدَكَ ضَالًّا فَهَدَىٰ ﴿٧﴾ وَوَجَدَكَ عَائِلًا فَأَغْنَىٰ
>
> **“Did He not find you an orphan and give you refuge? And He found you unaware and guided you, and found you poor and made you self-sufficient.”**
>
> Aḍ-Ḍuḥā 93:6–8.

As a boy he went with Abū Ṭālib on a trade journey to Shām. At-Tirmidhī (3620) reports that a Christian monk at Buṣrā, known in the sīrah as **Baḥīrā**, recognised in him the signs of the final Prophet and urged Abū Ṭālib to take him home. He worked as a **shepherd**: “Allah did not send any prophet except that he herded sheep… I used to herd them for the people of Makkah for a few qīrāṭs” (al-Bukhārī, 2262).

Part 3 Youth and marriage

al-Amīn, the trustworthy

He grew up kept away by Allah from the sins of his people: he never worshipped an idol, drank wine or joined their shameful gatherings. Quraysh called him **aṣ-Ṣādiq al-Amīn**, the truthful, the trustworthy, and left their valuables with him. As a young man he was present at **Ḥilf al-Fuḍūl**, a pact among the clans of Quraysh to stand with any wronged person in Makkah, local or stranger, until his right was restored. He said later: "I witnessed in the house of ʿAbdullāh ibn Judʿān a pact that I would not trade for the finest red camels. If I were called to it in Islām, I would respond" (al-Bayhaqī and others).

Khadījah

Khadījah bint Khuwaylid was a noble and wealthy widow of Quraysh who traded through agents. She hired him to take her goods to Shām, and her servant Maysarah returned with stories of his honesty and character, and with great profit. She proposed marriage to him through a friend. The sīrah books say he was **twenty-five** and she was **forty**. She bore him all his children except Ibrāhīm: **al-Qāsim**, after whom he was called Abū al-Qāsim, **Zaynab**, **Ruqayyah**, **Umm Kulthūm**, **Fāṭimah** and **ʿAbdullāh**. His sons died young. For twenty-five years he took no other wife.

The Black Stone

When he was about thirty-five, Quraysh rebuilt the Kaʿbah after a flood had weakened it. When the time came to put the **Black Stone** back in its place, the clans quarrelled over who would have the honour, and almost came to blows. They agreed that the first man to enter the masjid would judge between them. It was Muḥammad ﷺ, and they said: "This is al-Amīn; we are content with him." He placed the Stone on a cloak, had the chief of each clan hold its edge and lift it together, then set it in place with his own hand (Aḥmad; al-Ḥākim).

Part 4 The first revelation

As he approached forty, he came to love solitude. He would take provisions and go to the **cave of Ḥirāʾ** on the Mountain of Light above Makkah, spending nights in worship, before returning to Khadījah for more. ʿĀʾishah said revelation began with **true dreams**: every dream he saw came true like the break of dawn (al-Bukhārī, 3).

Then, in Ramaḍān, when he was forty, the angel **Jibrīl** came to him in the cave and said: "**Read!**" He said: "I am not one who reads." The angel pressed him hard, then released him and said again: "Read!" Three times; then:

اقْرَأْ بِاسْمِ رَبِّكَ الَّذِي خَلَقَ ﴿١﴾ خَلَقَ الْإِنسَانَ مِنْ عَلَقٍ ﴿٢﴾ اقْرَأْ وَرَبُّكَ الْأَكْرَمُ ﴿٣﴾ الَّذِي عَلَّمَ بِالْقَلَمِ ﴿٤﴾ عَلَّمَ الْإِنسَانَ مَا لَمْ يَعْلَمْ

“Read in the name of your Lord who created; created man from a clinging clot. Read, and your Lord is the Most Generous, who taught by the pen, taught man what he did not know.”

Al-ʿAlaq 96:1–5, the first verses revealed (al-Bukhārī 3, Muslim 160).

He returned home trembling and said: “Cover me, cover me!” When his fear had passed, he told Khadījah: “I feared for myself.” She said:

كَلَّا وَاللَّهِ مَا يُخْزِيكَ اللَّهُ أَبَدًا، إِنَّكَ لَتَصِلُ الرَّحِمَ، وَتَحْمِلُ الْكَلَّ، وَتَكْسِبُ الْمَعْدُومَ، وَتَقْرِي الضَّيْفَ، وَتُعِينُ عَلَى نَوَائِبِ الْحَقِّ

“Never! By Allah, Allah will never disgrace you. You keep the ties of kinship, you carry the burdens of the weak, you give to the destitute, you honour the guest, and you help those struck by calamity.”

Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3) and Muslim (160).

She took him to her cousin **Waraqah ibn Nawfal**, an old blind man who had become a Christian and knew the earlier scriptures. Waraqah said: “This is the Nāmūs (the angel) whom Allah sent down to Mūsā. If only I were young, and alive when your people drive you out!” He asked: “Will they drive me out?” Waraqah said: “Yes. No man has ever come with what you have brought except that he was opposed” (al-Bukhārī, 3). Waraqah died soon after. Then revelation paused for a time, until Jibrīl came again and Allah revealed: “O you who covers himself, arise and warn” (al-Muddaththir 74:1–2) (al-Bukhārī, 4).

Part 5 The call: secret and public

The first believers

For about three years the Prophet ﷺ called people privately, beginning with those closest to him. The first to believe were his wife **Khadījah**, among the free men **Abū Bakr**, among the boys his cousin ʿ**Alī**, who lived in his house, and among the freed slaves **Zayd ibn Ḥārithah**. Through Abū Bakr, a respected merchant, came ʿ**Uthmān ibn ʿAffān, az-Zubayr ibn al-ʿAwwām, ʿAbd ar-Raḥmān ibn ʿAwf, Saʿd ibn Abī Waqqāṣ** and **Ṭalḥah ibn ʿUbaydillāh**. Soon others followed, many of them young, poor or slaves: Bilāl, Khabbāb, ʿAmmār and his parents, ʿAbdullāh ibn Masʿūd. They met secretly in the house of **al-Arqam ibn Abī al-Arqam** near aṣ-Ṣafā to learn the Qur'an.

"Warn your nearest kin"

Then Allah commanded: "And warn your nearest kindred" (ash-Shuʿarāʾ 26:214). The Prophet ﷺ climbed **aṣ-Ṣafā** and called out to the clans of Quraysh. When they gathered, he said: "If I told you that horsemen were in the valley about to attack you, would you believe me?" They said: "We have never known you to lie." He said: "Then I am a warner to you before a severe punishment." His uncle **Abū Lahab** said: "May you perish! Is this why you gathered us?" And Allah revealed Sūrat al-Masad: "May the hands of Abū Lahab perish, and he has perished" (al-Bukhārī 4770, 4971).

What the Prophet ﷺ called to

- **Tawḥīd**: to worship Allah alone and leave the idols.
- **Belief in the Hereafter**: resurrection, judgement, Paradise and Hell.
- **Good character**: truthfulness, keeping ties of kinship, caring for orphans and the poor, chastity, and an end to burying daughters.
- **The prayer**, which was prayed before the five prayers were made obligatory at al-Miʿrāj.

Quraysh first tried words. They called him a poet, a soothsayer, a madman, a sorcerer, and a liar, though they had never known him to lie. Allah answered each charge in the Qur'an. They asked his uncle Abū Ṭālib to stop him or hand him over; Abū Ṭālib refused. The sīrah books tell how they sent ʿ**Utbah ibn Rabīʿah** to offer him wealth, leadership or kingship if he would stop; the Prophet ﷺ recited the beginning of Sūrat Fuṣṣilat, and ʿUtbah returned to Quraysh shaken, telling them to leave him alone.

Part 6 Persecution

When words failed, Quraysh turned to violence, above all against Muslims who had no tribe to protect them.

- **Bilāl ibn Rabāḥ**, an Abyssinian slave, was laid on the burning sand at midday with a rock on his chest by his master Umayyah ibn Khalaf, to make him leave Islām. The sīrah books say he only repeated: "Aḥad, Aḥad" (One, One). Abū Bakr bought him and freed him.

- **Yāsir and Sumayyah**, with their son ʿ**Ammār**, were tortured by Banū Makhzūm. The Prophet ﷺ passed them and said: "Patience, O family of Yāsir, for your appointment is Paradise" (al-Ḥākim). Abū Jahl killed Sumayyah, the **first martyr of Islām**; Yāsir died under torture. ʿAmmār, under torture, spoke words of disbelief with his tongue while his heart was at rest with faith, and Allah excused him (an-Naḥl 16:106).
- **Khabbāb ibn al-Aratt** was branded with hot iron. He came to the Prophet ﷺ asking him to pray for help, and was told how believers before them had been sawn in half without leaving their religion: "By Allah, Allah will complete this matter… but you are impatient" (al-Bukhārī, 3612).
- **Abū Bakr** spent his wealth buying and freeing tortured slaves, among them Bilāl and ʿĀmir ibn Fuhayrah.

The Prophet ﷺ himself

His family's protection did not stop Quraysh from harming him. Once, while he was in sujūd by the Kaʿbah, ʿUqbah ibn Abī Muʿayṭ brought the entrails of a slaughtered camel and dropped them on his back, while Abū Jahl and his companions laughed until they fell on each other. He stayed in sujūd until young **Fāṭimah** came and removed them (al-Bukhārī, 240). Another time, ʿUqbah twisted a cloth round his neck and strangled him hard, until Abū Bakr pushed him away, saying: "Would you kill a man because he says: My Lord is Allah?" (al-Bukhārī, 3678; Ghāfir 40:28).

Part 7 Abyssinia, Ḥamzah and ʿUmar

The hijrah to Abyssinia

In the fifth year of Prophethood, the Prophet ﷺ told the persecuted Muslims to go to **Abyssinia** (al-Ḥabashah), "for there is a king there under whom no one is wronged," as the sīrah books report. A first group of about eleven men and four women left, among them **ʿUthmān** and his wife **Ruqayyah**, the Prophet's ﷺ daughter. A larger group of more than eighty followed, led by **Jaʿfar ibn Abī Ṭālib**.

Quraysh sent **ʿAmr ibn al-ʿĀṣ** and ʿAbdullāh ibn Abī Rabīʿah with gifts to the king, the **Najāshī**, asking him to hand the Muslims back. Umm Salamah narrated that the Najāshī called the Muslims to answer. Jaʿfar said: "O king, we were a people of ignorance, worshipping idols, eating dead animals, committing indecencies, cutting ties of kinship, mistreating neighbours, the strong among us devouring the weak. Then Allah sent us a Messenger from among us, whose lineage, truthfulness, trustworthiness and chastity we knew. He called us to Allah, to worship Him alone…" The Najāshī asked to hear some of what he brought, and Jaʿfar recited the beginning of **Sūrat Maryam**. The king wept until his beard was wet, and his bishops wept, and he said: "This and what Mūsā brought come from the same lamp," and refused to hand them over (Aḥmad, with a good chain). When the Najāshī died years later as a Muslim, the Prophet ﷺ led the funeral prayer for him in absence (al-Bukhārī 1245, Muslim 951).

Ḥamzah and ʿUmar

In the sixth year, two of the strongest men of Quraysh accepted Islām. The sīrah books tell that **Ḥamzah**, the Prophet's ﷺ uncle, returned from hunting and heard that Abū Jahl had insulted his nephew; he went to Abū Jahl and struck him with his bow, saying: "Do you insult him when I follow his religion?" A few days later came **ʿUmar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb**, in answer to the Prophet's ﷺ duʿāʾ: "O Allah, strengthen Islām with whichever of these two men is more beloved to You: Abū Jahl or ʿUmar" (at-Tirmidhī, 3681). Ibn Masʿūd said: "We have been strong ever since ʿUmar accepted Islām" (al-Bukhārī, 3684). The Muslims began to pray openly at the Kaʿbah.

Part 8 The boycott and the Year of Sorrow

Three years in the valley

In the seventh year, Quraysh wrote a pact and hung it inside the Kaʿbah: no one would marry, trade with or sell food to **Banū Hāshim and Banū al-Muṭṭalib** until they handed over Muḥammad ﷺ. The Prophet's ﷺ clan, Muslims and non-Muslims alike, were confined to the valley of Abū Ṭālib (al-Bukhārī 1590 mentions the pact). For about three years they suffered such hunger that, the sīrah books say, they ate leaves and the cries of their children could be heard outside. A few men of Quraysh, moved by conscience, worked to end it; when they went to tear up the pact, they found that termites had eaten it, all except the words "**In Your name, O Allah**", as the Prophet ﷺ had told Abū Ṭālib.

The Year of Sorrow

In the tenth year, shortly after the boycott ended, the Prophet ﷺ lost his two greatest supporters. **Abū Ṭālib**, who had protected him for forty years, fell ill. The Prophet ﷺ sat by him and pleaded: "O uncle, say lā ilāha illā Allāh, a word by which I can argue for you before Allah." But Abū Jahl and another were with him, and he died on the religion of ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib. Allah revealed: "Indeed, you do not guide whom you love, but Allah guides whom He wills" (al-Qaṣaṣ 28:56) (al-Bukhārī 3884, Muslim 24).

Then **Khadījah** died, about three years before the Hijrah (al-Bukhārī, 3896). He never forgot her. ʿĀʾishah said she was never jealous of any woman as she was of Khadījah, though she never saw her, because of how often he mentioned her (al-Bukhārī, 3818). He said: "The best of its women is Maryam, and the best of its women is Khadījah" (al-Bukhārī 3432, Muslim 2430). Jibrīl brought her the greeting of her Lord, and glad tidings of a house of pearl in Paradise, where there is no noise and no fatigue (al-Bukhārī, 3820).

aṭ-Ṭāʾif

With Abū Ṭālib gone, Quraysh grew bolder. The Prophet ﷺ walked to **aṭ-Ṭāʾif**, the town of Thaqīf, with Zayd ibn Ḥārithah, hoping they would accept Islām and support him. Its leaders mocked him and set their slaves and youths on him; they stoned him until his feet bled. He later told ʿĀʾishah it was the hardest day he faced. Overwhelmed, he did not recover until he reached Qarn ath-Thaʿālib, where Jibrīl came with the angel of the mountains, who offered to crush the people of Makkah between the two mountains. He said:

> بَلْ أَرْجُو أَنْ يُخْرِجَ اللَّهُ مِنْ أَصْلَابِهِمْ مَنْ يَعْبُدُ اللَّهَ وَحْدَهُ لَا يُشْرِكُ بِهِ شَيْئًا
>
> **"Rather, I hope that Allah will bring from their descendants people who will worship Allah alone, associating nothing with Him."**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3231) and Muslim (1795).

The sīrah books tell how, resting in a garden, a Christian slave named **ʿAddās** brought him grapes and was amazed to hear him say "Bismillāh" and speak of Yūnus, "my brother, a prophet"; ʿAddās kissed his hands and feet. On the way back, at Nakhlah, a group of **jinn** heard him reciting the Qur'an in prayer and believed (al-Aḥqāf 46:29–31; Sūrat al-Jinn). He re-entered Makkah under the protection of **al-Muṭʿim ibn ʿAdī**, an idolater who was later remembered for it with gratitude (al-Bukhārī, 3139).

Part 9 al-Isrāʾ wal-Miʿrāj

سُبْحَانَ الَّذِي أَسْرَىٰ بِعَبْدِهِ لَيْلًا مِّنَ الْمَسْجِدِ الْحَرَامِ إِلَى الْمَسْجِدِ الْأَقْصَى الَّذِي بَارَكْنَا حَوْلَهُ

“Exalted is He who took His servant by night from al-Masjid al-Ḥarām to al-Masjid al-Aqṣā, whose surroundings We have blessed.”

Al-Isrāʾ 17:1.

After years of grief, Allah honoured His Messenger with a journey no one had made before. One night, Jibrīl came to him in Makkah, opened and washed his chest, and brought him **al-Burāq**, a white mount smaller than a mule and larger than a donkey, whose stride reached as far as its sight. He rode to **Bayt al-Maqdis** in Jerusalem, where he led the prophets in prayer. Then he was taken up through the seven heavens, meeting Ādam, Yaḥyā and ʿĪsā, Yūsuf, Idrīs, Hārūn, Mūsā, and Ibrāhīm, who was leaning against **al-Bayt al-Maʿmūr**, which seventy thousand angels enter every day and never return to. He reached **Sidrat al-Muntahā**, the Lote Tree of the Boundary (an-Najm 53:13–18), and saw Paradise (al-Bukhārī 3887, Muslim 162–164).

The gift of the prayer

There Allah made **fifty prayers** a day obligatory on his Ummah. On the way down, Mūsā asked him what his Lord had commanded, and said: “Your Ummah will not be able to bear it; go back and ask Him to lighten it.” He went back again and again until they became **five**, and Allah said: “They are five, and they are fifty; My word does not change” (al-Bukhārī 349, Muslim 162). So the five prayers carry the reward of fifty.

In the morning he told Quraysh, who mocked him and asked him to describe Jerusalem, which he had never visited before. Allah showed it to him, and he described it to them gate by gate (al-Bukhārī 3886, Muslim 170). It is reported that some went to Abū Bakr, expecting him to doubt, and he said: “If he said it, then it is true,” and so he was named **aṣ-Ṣiddīq** (al-Ḥākim).

For students

The scholars differ on the date of al-Isrāʾ wal-Miʿrāj, giving various years between the tenth year of Prophethood and the year before the Hijrah. The popular date of 27 Rajab is not established by an authentic report.

The majority of Ahl as-Sunnah hold that the journey was made **in body and soul**, while awake, which is why Quraysh found it so hard to believe.

Part 10 The pledges of al-ʿAqabah and the Hijrah

Seeking support among the tribes

Every pilgrimage season the Prophet ﷺ went to the tribes camped at Minā and the markets, asking: "Who will shelter me, who will support me, so that I may convey the message of my Lord?" Tribe after tribe refused, with Abū Lahab following behind him calling him a liar. Then, in the eleventh year, he met **six men of the Khazraj** from Yathrib (Madinah). Their Jewish neighbours had told them that a prophet would soon appear, and they said to each other: "This is the prophet they threaten us with; do not let them reach him before us." They accepted Islām and returned home to spread it.

The first pledge of al-ʿAqabah

The next year, **twelve men** came and met him at **al-ʿAqabah** near Minā. They pledged "that we would not associate anything with Allah, not steal, not commit adultery, not kill our children, not bring a slander we invent, and not disobey you in what is good" (al-Bukhārī 18, from ʿUbādah ibn aṣ-Ṣāmit, who was one of them). The Prophet ﷺ sent **Muṣʿab ibn ʿUmayr** back with them, the first teacher of Islām in Madinah. Within a year, it is reported, there was hardly a house of the Anṣār without Muslims in it, and two great chiefs of the Aws, **Usayd ibn Ḥuḍayr** and **Saʿd ibn Muʿādh**, had accepted Islām.

The second pledge of al-ʿAqabah

In the thirteenth year, about **seventy-three men and two women** from Madinah met the Prophet ﷺ secretly at night at al-ʿAqabah. His uncle al-ʿAbbās, not yet Muslim, came to make sure his nephew would be safe with them. They pledged to listen and obey in ease and hardship, to spend in plenty and scarcity, to command good and forbid evil, and to **protect him as they protected their own wives and children**, with Paradise as their reward. He chose **twelve leaders** (nuqabāʾ) from among them (Aḥmad, from Jābir and Kaʿb ibn Mālik).

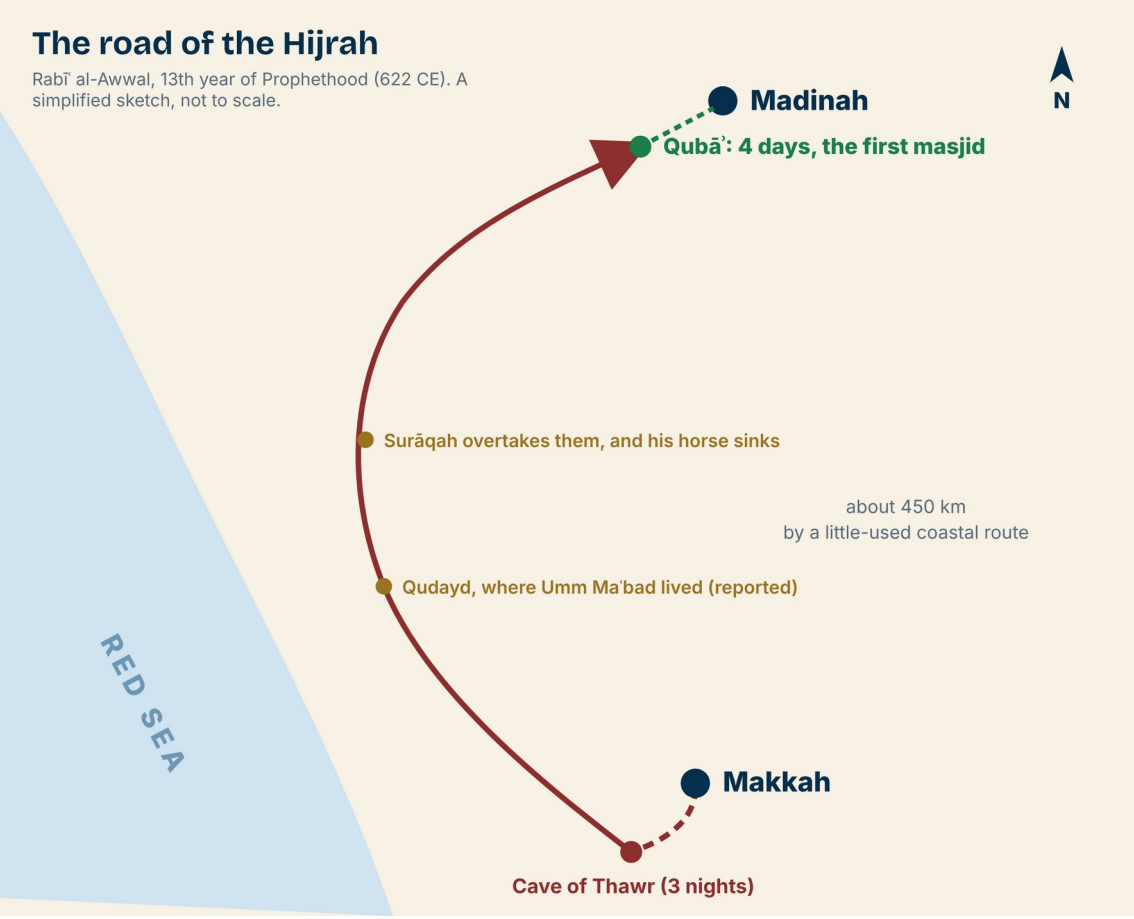
The Hijrah

The Prophet ﷺ gave the Muslims of Makkah permission to emigrate, and they left in small groups, many secretly, leaving homes and wealth behind. Ṣuhayb ar-Rūmī gave Quraysh all his wealth in exchange for being allowed to leave, and it is reported that the Prophet ﷺ said: "Your trade has profited, Abū Yaḥyā." Soon only the Prophet ﷺ, Abū Bakr, ʿAlī and those held back by force remained.

Quraysh met in their council house, **Dār an-Nadwah**, and agreed on a plan: a young man from every clan would strike him together, so that his clan could not take revenge on all of Quraysh. Allah told His Messenger:

> وَإِذْ يَمْكُرُ بِكَ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا لِيُثْبِتُوكَ أَوْ يَقْتُلُوكَ أَوْ يُخْرِجُوكَ ۚ وَيَمْكُرُونَ وَيَمْكُرُ اللَّهُ ۖ وَاللَّهُ خَيْرُ الْمَاكِرِينَ
>
> **“And [remember] when those who disbelieved plotted against you to restrain you, or kill you, or drive you out. They plan, and Allah plans; and Allah is the best of planners.”**
>
> Al-Anfāl 8:30.

The sīrah books tell how that night ʿ**Alī** slept in the Prophet’s ﷺ bed under his green cloak, and stayed behind to return the trusts people had left with him: even his enemies kept their valuables with al-Amīn. The Prophet ﷺ came to Abū Bakr at midday, an unusual hour, and told him that permission to emigrate had come. Abū Bakr wept with joy that he would be his companion (al-Bukhārī, 3905).



The cave of Thawr

They left by night and went south, the opposite direction to Madinah, to the **cave of Thawr**, where they hid for three nights. Abū Bakr’s son ʿ**Abdullāh** stayed with them at night and returned to Makkah before dawn to hear the news; his freed slave ʿ**Āmir ibn Fuhayrah** grazed sheep over their

tracks and brought them milk; his daughter **Asmāʾ** tore her waistband in two to tie up their provisions, and was called **Dhāt an-Niṭāqayn**, "she of the two waistbands" (al-Bukhārī 2979, 3905). The trackers of Quraysh came right to the mouth of the cave. Abū Bakr said: "O Messenger of Allah, if one of them looked down at his feet, he would see us." He replied:

> مَا ظَنُّكَ يَا أَبَا بَكْرٍ بِاثْنَيْنِ اللَّهُ ثَالِثُهُمَا
>
> **"What do you think, O Abū Bakr, of two whose third is Allah?"**
>
> Narrated by al-Bukhārī (3653) and Muslim (2381). Allah says: "…when he said to his companion: Do not grieve; indeed Allah is with us" (at-Tawbah 9:40).

The road to Madinah

After three nights, a guide they had hired, **ʿAbdullāh ibn Urayqiṭ**, a skilled guide who was not yet Muslim, brought their camels, and they took a little-used route near the coast (al-Bukhārī, 3905). Quraysh offered a hundred camels for each of them, dead or alive. **Surāqah ibn Mālik** rode after them; three times his horse's legs sank into the ground as he came near, until he asked for a guarantee of safety and turned back, turning other pursuers away (al-Bukhārī, 3906). The sīrah books add that the Prophet ﷺ told him he would one day wear the bracelets of Kisrā, which came true in the caliphate of ʿUmar. They also tell of **Umm Maʿbad**, a poor woman at Qudayd whose dry goat gave milk when the Prophet ﷺ milked it, and of her famous description of him.

Arrival

Every morning the Muslims of Madinah went out to the lava field to wait for him, until the midday heat drove them home. One day a Jewish man on a lookout saw them and cried: "O people of the Arabs, here is the one you are waiting for!" (al-Bukhārī, 3906). The Prophet ﷺ stayed some days at **Qubāʾ**, where he founded the first masjid of Islām (at-Tawbah 9:108), then rode into Madinah. Al-Barāʾ said: "I never saw the people of Madinah rejoice at anything as they rejoiced at the Messenger of Allah ﷺ" (al-Bukhārī, 3925). Every family wanted him to stay with them; he let his camel choose, and where she knelt he built his masjid and his home. The Hijrah marked the beginning of the Islamic calendar, chosen in the time of ʿUmar.

Lessons What the Makkan years teach us

Lessons for us

1	**Allah prepares those He chooses.** Orphanhood, shepherding and trade prepared the Prophet ﷺ to care for the weak, to be patient and to lead.
2	**Character opens hearts.** Before he called anyone, Makkah already knew him as al-Amīn.
3	**Begin with tawḥīd.** Thirteen years were spent above all on belief in Allah and the Hereafter.
4	**Patience is the way of the prophets.** The Companions endured torture, boycott and exile without fighting back, because Allah had not yet permitted it.
5	**Support the truth with what you have.** Khadījah her wealth and comfort, Abū Bakr his fortune, Asmāʾ her waistband, ʿAlī his own life.
6	**After hardship comes ease.** The Year of Sorrow was followed by al-Miʿrāj, and the rejection of aṭ-Ṭāʾif by the pledges of Madinah.
7	**Take the means and trust Allah**, as in the planning of the Hijrah: the cave, the guide, the hidden tracks, and then “two whose third is Allah”.

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. **On which day of the week was the Prophet ﷺ born?**
   a) Friday b) Monday c) Thursday d) Sunday

2. **Who was his wet-nurse in the desert?**
   a) Āminah b) Barakah c) Ḥalīmah as-Saʿdiyyah d) Khadījah

3. **Where did his mother Āminah die?**
   a) al-Abwāʾ b) Madinah c) aṭ-Ṭāʾif d) Makkah

4. **What were the first verses revealed?**
   a) Al-Fātiḥah b) The opening of al-Muddaththir c) The opening of al-ʿAlaq d) Āyat al-Kursī

5. **Who said: “By Allah, Allah will never disgrace you”?**
   a) Abū Bakr b) Khadījah c) Waraqah d) Abū Ṭālib

6. Who was the first martyr of Islām?

a) Sumayyah b) Yāsir c) Bilāl d) Ḥamzah

7. Which sūrah did Jaʿfar recite before the Najāshī?

a) Yā Sīn b) Al-Kahf c) Ṭā Hā d) Maryam

8. Which sūrah was revealed about Abū Lahab?

a) Al-Masad b) Al-Humazah c) Al-Kāfirūn d) Al-Fīl

9. How long did the boycott in the valley last?

a) About three months b) About three years c) Ten years d) Forty days

10. What did the Prophet ﷺ hope for the people of aṭ-Ṭāʾif?

a) Their destruction b) That their descendants would worship Allah c) That they would leave Arabia d) That they would pay jizyah

11. At al-Miʿrāj, how many prayers were first made obligatory?

a) Five b) Ten c) Fifty d) Seventeen

12. Who was sent to Madinah as the first teacher after the first pledge?

a) Muṣʿab ibn ʿUmayr b) Ibn Masʿūd c) Zayd ibn Ḥārithah d) Bilāl

13. Where did the Prophet ﷺ and Abū Bakr hide for three nights?

a) Ḥirāʾ b) Thawr c) Uḥud d) Qubāʾ

14. Why was Asmāʾ called Dhāt an-Niṭāqayn?

a) She tore her waistband to tie up the provisions b) She wore two belts c) She had two sons d) She carried two swords

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) Monday	8	a) Al-Masad
2	c) Ḥalīmah	9	b) About three years
3	a) al-Abwāʾ	10	b) Their descendants
4	c) al-ʿAlaq	11	c) Fifty
5	b) Khadījah	12	a) Muṣʿab
6	a) Sumayyah	13	b) Thawr
7	d) Maryam	14	a) The waistband

For further reading

- **Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī**, the Book of the Beginning of Revelation and the Book of the Virtues of the Anṣār.
- **As-Sīrah an-Nabawiyyah** of Ibn Hishām, from Ibn Isḥāq.
- **Ar-Raḥīq al-Makhtūm** (The Sealed Nectar) of Ṣafiyyur-Raḥmān al-Mubārakpūrī.
- **Ash-Shamāʾil al-Muḥammadiyyah** of at-Tirmidhī, on his appearance and character.

- Our companion book, **The Battles of the Prophet ﷺ**, for the Madinan years.

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وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

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